

September 5, 2026

Catalina L. Toma, PhD
Associate Editor
Computers in Human Behavior

Dear Dr. Toma,

We are pleased to submit the revised version of manuscript CHB-D-26-04350R1, “Newcomers Help Most After Being Helped, Veterans Do Not: Evidence from Stack Overflow,” following your minor-revision decision. We thank you and both reviewers for the assessment, and we are grateful to Reviewer 1 for recommending acceptance and to Reviewer 2 for a set of requests that we think have made the paper more honest about what it does and does not establish.

No estimate in the manuscript has changed in this round. Every number is the same pipeline run reported in the first revision, and the revision is confined to framing, figures, one new descriptive figure, and copyediting. A point-by-point response accompanies this letter.

In brief, we have made all four changes Reviewer 2 asked for. First, the Abstract and Introduction now frame the study as a pre-generative-AI baseline that locates a narrow effect rather than as a general test of reciprocity; we moved the two boundaries — how narrow the effect is, and how dated it is — forward into the Introduction’s contribution section, so that a reader meets them before the results rather than after. Second, the response-time figure now carries the answer-quality-controlled estimates in the main text, stacked beneath the baseline estimates on a shared axis, so that the shrinkage of the 30–60-minute peak from 1.19 to 1.03 is visible rather than confined to an appendix table. Third, we consolidated the redundant raw-help-rate visualizations: the three in the main text are now a single two-panel figure, the by-tenure versions are gathered in one appendix, and a new sample-construction flow diagram traces the sample from the public dump through matching to the Cox analysis sample. The main text therefore carries five figures where the first revision carried six, despite the addition of the flow diagram. Fourth, the Discussion now states the common-support restriction explicitly: because our exact strata are calendar year, primary tag, and number of tags, what we estimate is the effect for answered questions in mainstream, well-trafficked tag areas rather than for the long tail of niche topics.

Both reviewers answered “yes” to the language-editing question. We ran a copyediting pass over the passages this revision touches, re-staging long sentences rather than cutting content, so that no caveat or qualification was lost. That pass also caught a cross-reference defect that

survived the first revision, in which references to appendix sections rendered as “Appendix Appendix C”; all six occurrences are corrected. We would be glad to have the manuscript go through Elsevier’s language service at production if you would still prefer it.

The manuscript remains an original contribution that is not under consideration elsewhere, and all authors have approved this revised version. Authorship is unchanged. We declare no competing interests. Alongside the revised manuscript in editable L^AT_EX source form we enclose the point-by-point response to reviewers, the Highlights file (now five bullet points), the title page, and the declaration of competing interests. We respectfully decline the optional Graphical Abstract and Research Elements submissions.

We hope the revised manuscript now meets the expectations of the reviewers and the journal, and we would be glad to provide any further analyses or clarifications.

Sincerely,

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on behalf of all authors: Lenard Strahringer, Sven Eric Pruess, and Kai Riemer